InterAcademix – Collaboration Across Academics

Executive Summary:

The problem faced is the lack of a centralised platform for facilitating collaboration and knowledge sharing across different schools and disciplines within the organisation. There are various platforms like Canvas, Microsoft Teams, and websites, but no unified solution for networking, finding relevant experts, and discovering interdisciplinary opportunities.

Solving this problem is crucial for promoting innovation and fostering a collaborative culture within the organisation. By bringing diverse perspectives and expertise together, interdisciplinary collaborations can lead to more robust and creative outcomes, driving the organisation's research and academic excellence.

The proposed solution is a unified collaboration platform that serves as a centralised hub for profiles, intelligent matching, collaboration tools, events, and opportunities. It aims to streamline finding suitable collaborators, enhance knowledge sharing, and promote interdisciplinary initiatives.

The development and deployment of the solution will require an estimated investment of £130,000, covering platform development, salaries, marketing, and deployment costs. The platform is expected to generate revenue through subscription fees and premium content offerings.

By implementing our solution, the organisation will facilitate interdisciplinary research, promote knowledge sharing, reduce manual efforts in finding collaborators, enhance the visibility of ongoing projects and events, and provide valuable data-driven insights for strategic decision-making.

The next steps involve securing the necessary resources, developing the platform, integrating with existing systems, and implementing a change management strategy to ensure widespread adoption across the organisation.

Context:

The original task is to understand better the collaborations happening around the organisation and provide an all-in-one solution for networking between the faculties, which will comprise knowledge sharing and collaboration between the schools. The organisation currently has platforms like Canvas for organised virtual learning, Microsoft Teams for communicating and the University website as an information source of contacts, events, research, workshops, and more. Currently, there is not any single centralised platform or interlink between these various platforms. Furthermore, the organisation wants a solution to be able to find the required person/source of information inside the complex network infrastructure of organisations and must be easy to use among consumers, which will reduce the hassle of searching. Many of the organisations will likely have this problem because we assumed that Graham, a Sage Faculty member interacted with other universities, and they encountered such problems too. InterAcademix recognised that there are 3 customer groups for this problem, they are lecturers, researchers and students – our focus is the lecturers.

Need:

Based on the customer journey map, the key needs of the lecturer customer segment that InterAcademix aims to address are:

Centralized Access to Information: The map highlights the challenges lecturers face in finding relevant information, such as researching across multiple university websites, portals, and documentation. This scattered and decentralized approach leads to inefficiencies, time consumption, and uncertainty about where to look for the required data.

Streamlined Collaboration and Expertise Discovery: The journey of finding related departments, relevant teams, specialists, or experts with specific knowledge involves substantial manual effort. Lecturers must navigate through contacting offices, matching requirements, and obtaining contact details, which is a tedious and time-consuming process.

Enabling Interdisciplinary Collaboration: The map reveals the lack of a dedicated space or platform that facilitates collaboration, knowledge sharing, and problem-solving across different departments and disciplines. This siloed approach hinders interdisciplinary innovation and the cross-pollination of ideas.

By mapping the customer journey, our group gained a deeper understanding of the pain points lecturers face, which informed our perspective on the need for a centralized platform like InterAcademix. The investigation revealed that these issues are not isolated but pervasive across the organization, impacting productivity, collaboration, and ultimately, the organization's ability to drive innovation.

The decentralized nature of information, the manual efforts required for finding collaborators and expertise, and the lack of interdisciplinary connectivity create significant inefficiencies for lecturers. These challenges not only impact the lecturers' workflow but also have broader implications for the organization, such as missed opportunities for research collaborations, slower knowledge dissemination, and limited cross-pollination of ideas.

Through this module, our group's understanding of the problem evolved from merely recognizing the existence of disparate systems to appreciating the deeper ramifications of these inefficiencies on the organization's ability to foster a collaborative and innovative environment. InterAcademix, therefore, aims to address these needs by providing a unified platform that centralizes information, streamlines collaboration, and promotes interdisciplinary connectivity, enabling lecturers to focus on their core academic pursuits while driving innovation for the organization.

Vision:

InterAcademix envisions providing a central collaboration hub tailored for lecturers across different schools and disciplines within the organization. The platform's key value propositions cater specifically to the needs and workflows of lecturers:

Centralized Hub: Lecturers currently struggle with fragmented systems and isolated information. InterAcademix will offer a single, unified platform consolidating all the necessary data, resources, and collaboration tools, enabling easy access and discovery of relevant information.

Dissemination and Expertise Sharing: The platform will facilitate knowledge dissemination and sharing of expertise among lecturers. User profiles will showcase individual research areas, publications, and ongoing projects, allowing lecturers to identify potential collaborators with complementary expertise easily.

Interdisciplinary Collaboration: The platform will actively promote interdisciplinary collaboration by highlighting relevant events, research opportunities, and potential projects that bring together

diverse perspectives. This will foster innovation and cross-pollination of ideas across different fields of study.

Less Manual Effort: Finding the right contacts, expertise, and information currently involves significant manual effort for lecturers. Our platform will streamline this process through intelligent search, filtering, and recommendation capabilities, reducing time spent on administrative tasks.

The business model is centred around leveraging the knowledge and collaborative contributions of lecturers from different schools. Revenue streams will include subscription fees, licensing options, targeted advertising, and premium content offerings. Robust customer engagement initiatives like user forums, webinars, and community-building efforts will foster a sense of ownership and drive platform adoption among lecturers.

By providing a centralized hub tailored to lecturers' needs, facilitating expertise sharing, promoting interdisciplinary collaboration, and reducing administrative overhead, InterAcademix aims to develop a go-to platform for lecturers seeking to enhance their research, networking, and collaborative endeavours within the organisation.

Outcomes:

The proposed solution is to create a unified collaboration platform that brings together all the necessary tools and information required for effective collaboration across lecturers of different schools and disciplines within the organisation. Key features include:

1. Centralised Repository: A single source for accessing all academic information and resources. Our assumption is that the IT teams of the organisation (i.e. NUIT) would have APIs that update this information automatically. Hence our platform is connected through these APIs to get the current data.
2. Access to Diverse Educational Resources: Providing lecturers access to a wide range of educational materials across disciplines like workshops, research, and events.
3. Search and Filter Capabilities: Robust search and filtering tools for efficient information discovery and contact fetching of specific lecturer.
4. Integrated Communication Options: Built-in communication channels and collaboration tools for seamless teamwork. This includes integration of contact links of lecturers through Microsoft teams and Outlook.
5. Promotion of Interdisciplinary Collaboration: Actively highlighting and facilitating cross-disciplinary opportunities and connections.

These key features of the MVP lay the foundation for InterAcademix to develop a comprehensive and user-friendly platform that addresses the lecturer’s needs for centralised collaboration, knowledge sharing, and promoting interdisciplinary research and innovation.

Once the MVP is deployed within the organization, several changes will be evident. Firstly, there will be a noticeable shift towards centralized collaboration among lecturers from different schools and disciplines. The platform will serve as a hub for accessing academic information, resources, and communication tools, streamlining collaborative efforts and knowledge sharing across the organization.

The beneficiaries of the MVP's outputs include lecturers who will benefit from easier access to educational resources, streamlined communication channels, and enhanced opportunities for

interdisciplinary collaboration. Additionally, students may indirectly benefit from improved teaching methods and innovative research outcomes resulting from enhanced collaboration among lecturers.

Ownership and maintenance of the MVP is primarily our (InterAcademix) responsibility. Regular updates, maintenance, and troubleshooting will be necessary to ensure the platform's continued functionality and effectiveness in meeting the needs of its users.

Success of the MVP will be measured through various metrics, including user engagement, adoption rates, and feedback from lecturers and other stakeholders. Key performance indicators (KPIs) may include the number of active users, frequency of interactions within the platform, and the level of participation in interdisciplinary collaborations facilitated by the platform. Additionally, qualitative feedback from users regarding the platform's usability, effectiveness in promoting collaboration, and impact on teaching and research outcomes will be valuable in assessing its success.

References:

Module materials, Tatiana (module tutor), Saram(demonstrator), and Graham (problem owner)

https://www.projectmanager.com/blog/root-cause-analysis-guide

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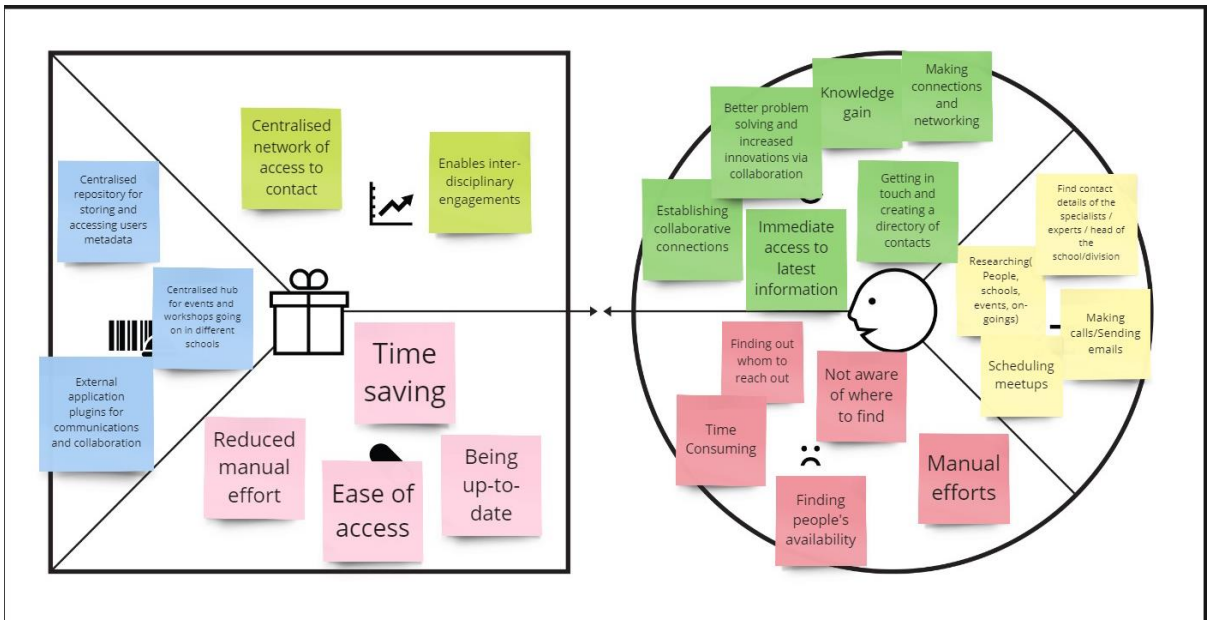
Generative AI for enhancements and verifications

Appendix

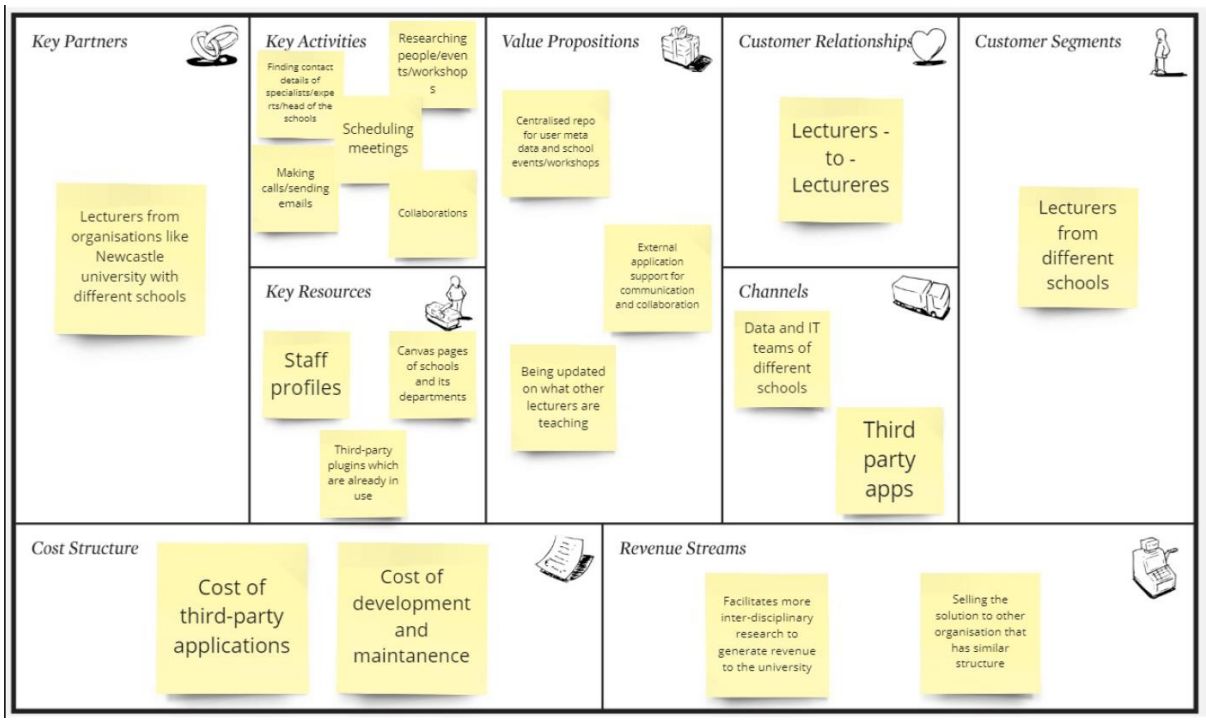
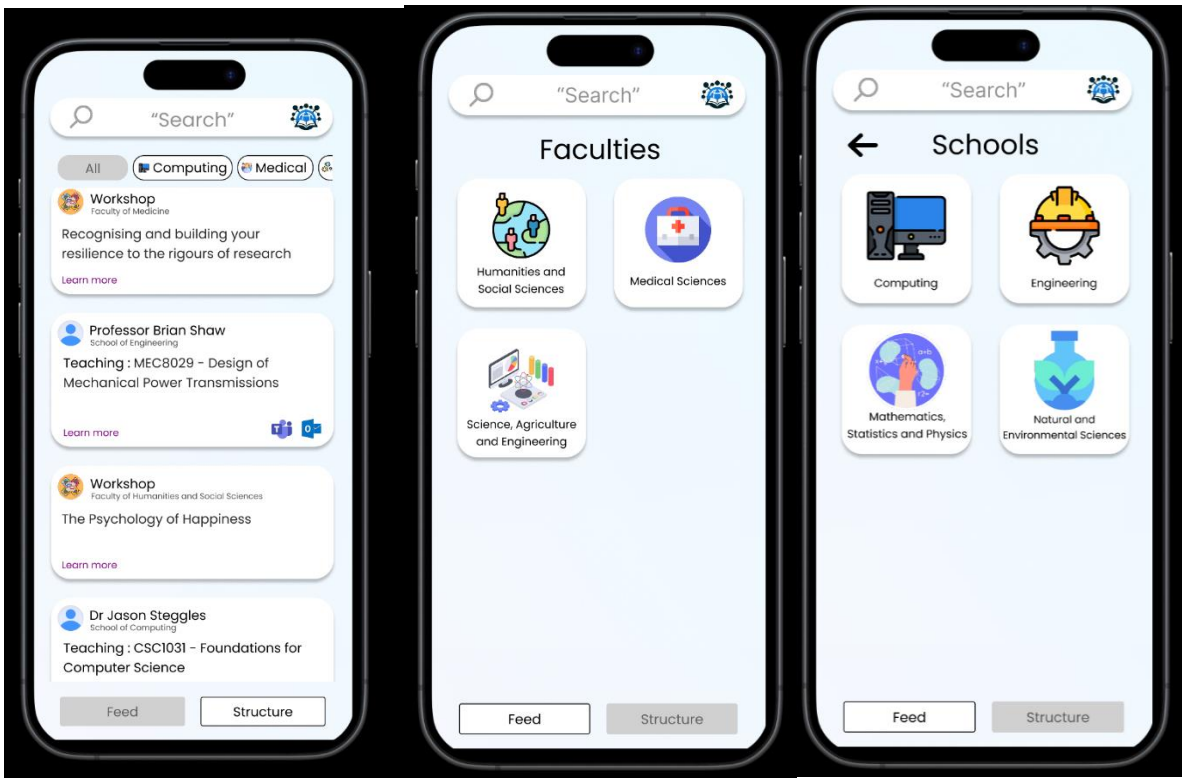
1. Customer Journey Map:

Stage	Understanding how to do	Finding related department	Finding the relevant team	connecting/collaborating/Knowledge share
Job(s)	o Researching(Searching on university websites or portals) o documenting	o Matching the requirements to departments in the university o Contacting the office	o Contacting the team o Finding the specialist/head contact details o Getting the contact details	o Reaching out to the person using the contact
Pains	Don't know where to research Time consuming	Requires manual effort	Requires manual effort	Decentralized space for collaboration
Gains	University portal has school and staff details	Immediate access to latest information	Immediate access to latest information	Better problem solving, increased innovation
Feeling				
Effort				

2. Value Proposition:



3. Business Model:



4. Minimum Viable Product Implementation: